

When the Bottom Fell Out

The Great Depression & the New Deal • 1929–1941 | Standards US.39, US.40, US.41, US.42, US.43, US.44

Archive (J. Troop) Spark Navigator
Notetaker

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

In 1929 the richest country on earth fell into its worst economic disaster, and one in four workers lost their jobs through no fault of their own. When the bottom falls out for millions of people, whose job is it to catch them — themselves, their neighbors, or their government? The answer America argued out in the 1930s still shapes your life today.

Hold this question the whole unit. You'll answer it at the end — in your own words, from the evidence.

1 Mission Vocabulary

Write what each word means as you meet it in the stories (definitions shown).

buying on margin	Buying stocks with mostly borrowed money — a major cause of the 1929 crash.	Dust Bowl	The 1930s ecological disaster when plowed-up Plains soil blew away in huge dust storms.
Hooverville	A shantytown of homeless Depression families, named mockingly for President Hoover.	rugged individualism	Hoover's belief that people should rely on themselves and private charity, not federal relief.
the New Deal	FDR's 1933–1939 programs to fight the Depression through Relief, Recovery, and Reform.	Relief, Recovery, Reform	The 'Three Rs' of the New Deal: help now, restart the economy, and fix the system long-term.
TVA	The Tennessee Valley Authority — a government agency that built dams and brought electricity to the rural South.	court-packing	FDR's failed 1937 plan to add Supreme Court justices who would uphold the New Deal.

2 Flight Log — every stop

One entry per landing. Jot what you *notice*, then answer the crew's debrief — the point isn't a right answer, it's your read of the evidence.

#	What Spark shows you & the crew's debrief	Key (one defensible read)
1	Analyze the interlocking causes of the Great Depression — margin buying, bank failures, overproduction, and the Smoot-Hawley Tariff. Notice: You buy something with money you don't have, betting you'll pay it back when your investment goes up. Everybody's doing it, so it feels safe.... Debrief: Explain how a stock market crash turned into a decade-long Depression. Identify at least three causes and show how one caused or worsened another.	Causes include margin buying (amplified the crash and left unpayable debts), bank failures (wiped out savings, no FDIC), overproduction (layoffs → less spending), agricultural weakness, and the Smoot-Hawley Tariff (collapsed world trade). Strong answers show a chain — e.g., crash → bank failures → business closings → unemployment → less spending → more failures — the vicious cycle that pushed unemployment to ~25%.
2	Analyze the human-caused ecological disaster of the Dust Bowl and the forced migration and discrimination it produced. Notice: Imagine the sky itself turning against you. A wall of black dust two thousand feet high, rolling across the horizon at sixty miles an hour... Debrief: Explain why the Dust Bowl is called a 'human-caused' disaster, not just a natural one. Then describe what happened to families like Opal's, and how <i>The Grapes of Wrath</i> changed public understanding.	Human-caused: farmers plowed up deep-rooted prairie grass that had held the soil, so when drought hit, the exposed topsoil blew away. Families lost farms and over 400,000 migrated west ('Okies'), facing discrimination and crashing wages in California. Steinbeck's <i>The Grapes of Wrath</i> (1939) portrayed the Joad family sympathetically, making Americans see migrants as dignified human beings. Strong answers connect the farming practices + drought and the human/social results.
3	Analyze the human toll of the Great Depression — mass unemployment, Hoovervilles, hunger, and the unequal way it fell. Notice: One in four. Picture your class, and cross out every fourth person's job — gone. Now imagine there's no unemployment check, no food stamps, no... Debrief: Describe three ways the Depression harmed ordinary Americans, and explain why it fell harder on some groups than others. Why might a photograph like 'Migrant Mother' change minds when statistics don't?	Harms (any three): ~25% unemployment; Hoovervilles/homelessness; breadlines and hunger; foreclosures; teenagers riding the rails; psychological trauma. It fell harder on groups already at the bottom — e.g., Black Americans were 'last hired, first fired' with much higher unemployment. A photograph like 'Migrant Mother' puts a human face on abstract numbers, creating empathy that statistics alone often don't. Strong answers address inequality explicitly.
4	Analyze Hoover's response to the Depression — 'rugged individualism,' the RFC, and the Bonus Army — and why it failed politically. Notice: You're the president. A quarter of the country is out of work, people are starving, and everyone is looking at you. You genuinely believe that if... Debrief: Explain Hoover's philosophy of 'rugged individualism' and how it shaped his response to the Depression. Then explain how the Bonus Army episode helped end his presidency. Was his philosophy wrong, or just wrong for this crisis? Defend your view.	Rugged individualism held that self-reliance and private charity, not federal relief, preserved American character; Hoover therefore avoided direct relief and used indirect tools like the RFC (trickle-down). The Bonus Army's violent dispersal (tear gas/tanks against veterans) horrified the public and helped cause his 1932 landslide loss. Strong answers take a defensible position on whether the philosophy itself or its fit to this crisis was the core problem.
5	Analyze FDR's New Deal through the 'Three Rs' — Relief, Recovery, and Reform — and the lasting institutions it created. Notice: A minimum wage. A limit on your work week. Insurance so your grandparents don't starve when they're old. Insurance so your family's bank savings... Debrief: Explain the 'Three Rs' of the New Deal with one program for each. Then explain one way the New Deal fell short of helping all Americans equally. Which New Deal program do you think mattered most, and why?	Relief (immediate help: CCC, WPA), Recovery (restart economy: AAA, NRA), Reform (long-term fixes: FDIC, SEC, Wagner Act, FLSA, Social Security). Shortfall: early Social Security excluded farm and domestic workers (many of them Black), and local administration could discriminate. Strong answers defend a 'most important' choice (e.g., Social Security or FDIC) with reasoning.
6	Analyze the Tennessee Valley Authority as the New Deal's most dramatic regional transformation — flood control, electrification, and its impact on... Notice: Flip a switch. Light. You've done it ten thousand times without a thought. Now imagine you're seventeen and you have never once done it — every... Debrief: Explain what the TVA did and why it mattered so much to the rural South. Then explain one benefit and one cost or controversy of a government building and owning something like the TVA.	The TVA (1933) built dams across the Tennessee Valley to control floods, improve navigation, and generate cheap electricity, bringing power to rural households where only ~10% had it. Benefit: it did what private companies wouldn't (wiring poor rural areas), transforming daily life and the regional economy. Cost/controversy: government-owned power competed with private companies (raising 'socialism' fears), and building dams flooded land and displaced some families. Strong answers give a real benefit and a real cost.
7	Analyze the opposition to the New Deal, the Supreme Court's rejection of key programs, and FDR's failed court-packing plan. Notice: What happens when a president does so much, so fast, that people start asking whether he's rescuing democracy or endangering it? The New Deal... Debrief: Explain why the New Deal faced opposition, how the Supreme Court responded, and why FDR's court-packing plan failed. What does this fight show about the balance of power in American government?	Opposition: critics (American Liberty League) called it socialism and government overreach. The Court struck down the NRA (1935) and AAA (1936) as unconstitutional. FDR's 1937 court-packing plan to add justices failed because even allies saw it as a dangerous power grab; the Court then began upholding New Deal laws anyway. The fight shows the checks and balances at work: the New Deal expanded federal power, but the Constitution constrained the president. Strong answers address that balance.

S Source Detective

Find this primary source in Unit 5 of your book, then work it like an investigator: **hoover-business-sound-1929**

1. Who made this, and when? Whose point of view does it show — and whose is missing?
2. Spark's question: *Four days later the market suffered the worst crash in its history, and within four years more than 9,000 banks had failed. Ask: why would the...*
3. What does this source prove — and what does it *not* prove on its own?

Teacher note: US.39 and the bridge from Unit 4. Dot's continuity pays off the credit-boom cliffhanger. Keep causes interlocking, not a list. TN anchor: Caldwell and Company, Nashville.

A The Arc of the Union — *your call*

For each milestone, decide: did it move the country **toward** its founding promise — liberty and equality *for all* — or **away**? There's no answer key. Mark your read and back it with evidence.

Year	Milestone	Historians' read (one reading, not the answer)
1929	The stock market crash	Setback Universally treated as the onset of the worst economic disaster in U.S. history — an unambiguous setback.
1932	The Bonus Army is driven from Washington	Setback Broadly seen as a low point of the Hoover years — the federal government using force against veterans seeking help.
1933	The New Deal begins	Climb Widely regarded as a landmark expansion of government's responsibility for economic security, though its size is genuinely debated — so consensus...
1933	The TVA lights up the Tennessee Valley	Climb Broadly celebrated as a transformative public-works success that modernized a whole region — with the acknowledged cost that some families were...
1935	Social Security is enacted	Climb Regarded as one of the most important laws in U.S. history and a major advance in economic security, though its initial exclusions (farm and...
1937	The court-packing plan fails	Mixed Genuinely contested: some see the plan's failure as democracy protecting itself from overreach, others as an obstacle to needed reform — so it is...

B Debrief & Closing Argument

This unit is where America rewrites the deal between a person and their government. For 150 years the answer to 'who catches you when you fall'...

Closing question: The New Deal permanently expanded what the federal government does for ordinary people — and Americans have argued about whether that was rescue or overreach ever since. Using at least two programs from this unit, argue whether the New Deal moved the country closer to its founding promise or further from it. Then name one thing it left unfinished. Cite the unit — there's no answer key.

Facilitation: There is no single correct verdict — students must choose moments and defend a direction with evidence. Reward a claim that holds competing truths (opportunity *and* injustice in the same years) over a tidy one-sided answer.

Back to the Essential Question — your answer now:

Answers vary; look for direct use of unit evidence and a defensible position, not a memorized "right" answer.